the stolen item, the village head could get between several hundred and 2,000 kyats. The other example involved buying and selling land, where the village headman would get a percentage as "witness" fees.[26] If the village headman receives money for trivial jobs, how much would a village tract leader get if he helped to settle land disputes? This is the informal economy that helps sustain order at the micro level.

It is not known whether the village tract leaders were already part of the elite in their respective areas before their appointment by the PNO, however, their power over the villagers is clear. Backed by the PNO and the armed soldiers of the PNA, they imposed themselves as the supreme authority in the village tract. Village headmen settle everyday disputes, such as petty thefts or marital problems. More complicated issues, such as land grabbing, are referred to the village tract leader, and if the issue is still not resolved, then the PNO/PNA will ensure the case is settled by the use of force.[27]

Village headmen are not appointed by the PNO. Villagers nominate them in what seems to be quite a democratic manner. However, in the nine villages studied, five headmen said they were reluctant to assume the role because they did not get paid. Moreover, they often found themselves having to deal with villagers' grievances because the village tract leader failed to respond to their requests. A headman of a village in Ho Pong township is a case in point. The village is located about 1.5 kilometres from the main road, but the surface of the existing path is full of potholes, which makes the village almost inaccessible during rainy seasons. For three years the villagers had been asking the village headman to raise the issue of paving a road to the village with the village tract leader. The village headman explained the procedure as follows. First, he has to discuss it with the village tract leader. If the leader agrees, he will prepare a proposal including a cost estimate and submit the application to the PNO at township level for authorization. Despite numerous meetings with the village tract leader, nothing has been done. However, villagers found out that a new road had been built in a nearby village in 2015. The first village's headman explained that the neighbouring village got its road because the village grew opium and paid the PNO and the villagers bribed the village tract leader, but the villagers still blamed him for not doing his job. It seems that the village headman has no power and has very little incentive to work for the villagers. On the other hand, the village tract leader has the means to get things done but the villagers aren't his concern because they do not